

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 130**Culture (OWC):** [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Eastern Africa**Field Date:** 1974-1976**Coverage Date:** 1970-1979**Place Coverage**

Morongo (a pseudonym), Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): LABOR AND DELIVERY

By 1974, however, the distinction between married and unmarried mothers was much less clear, because bridewealth had not been paid for the majority of women giving birth for the first time (and in many cases, the first three or four times). Thus, although they were living as the wives of men in terms of their social roles in everyday life, the lack of prior bridewealth payment put these women into the category of unmarried mothers by standards that had prevailed only 17 years earlier. This ambiguity in their social status gave rise to a diversity in the practice of hazing: Those women who were on good terms with their husband's family would probably be hazed only at first birth, regardless of whether their bridewealth had been paid; those not on good terms with their husband's family would be hazed even on their third and fourth births if bridewealth had not yet legitimized their unions. Thus, the ritual hazing that had been reserved for the first birth in the 1950s was being directed in the 1970s at women who had already borne children.

[178
Sociocultural Trends](#)[578
Ingroup Antagonisms](#)[844
Childbirth](#)[848
Illegitimacy](#)

The Gusii women we observed in labor endured this hazing without overt response. We never heard a woman cry out during labor, nor did we often hear of this. Having undergone in childhood the pain of clitoridectomy, and the hazing accompanying it, with a precocious courage demanded by the ritual, a Gusii woman has learned to endure impassively the pain of childbirth and the hostile laughter and joking sexual abuse that accompany it. The challenge of childbirth is to prove oneself again by producing a healthy infant with the dignity of silence and restraint that constitutes a moral virtue for a Gusii woman. The parallel with the  131 initiation ceremony is explicit, and informants speak of the woman confined during the after delivery as *omware*, meaning the secluded novice who has just undergone the circumcision or clitoridectomy operation.

152
Drives And Emotions

304
Body Alterations

577
Ethics

578
Ingroup Antagonisms

844
Childbirth

866
Independence Training

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)